



How to Train Your AI Dragon:

Email #5 - Writing & Editing

Hello! Welcome to email #5 of this short series for social scientists. (Was this forwarded? [Sign up here](#)).

In this email, I'm going to dive deeper into the writing and editing assistance available from AI tools like Claude, ChatGPT, and Gemini.

But first: obviously, dragons are not real. They are a legend, a metaphor, and a recurring theme in art, literature, and even music... but dragons are still just a fantasy. (Just like [goblins](#)!)

Similarly, it's a fantasy to imagine that AI tools can reason, think, or create in the same way as humans. What's not a fantasy is that these tools have been trained on vast oceans of material

produced by humans across the ages.

Given that these AI tools may well have ingested lots of science fiction and fantasy about AI, is it any wonder that, when prompted on things like whether or not they're sentient, they sometimes respond like something out of a sci-fi novel? Don't be fooled!

That said, many millions of people have found that these tools really excel in generating and editing text in various languages, including computer languages. Some may dismiss anything they generate as "slop." The truth is that what you get may be slop or successful depending on how you work with the tool. In other words, slop in, slop out.

The cardinal sin of using AI in writing is to claim those words as your own

Full disclosure: emails in this series have been drafted by me, then refined and edited using AI tools. Importantly, I always paraphrase, rewrite, and heavily edit whatever the AI spits out. I never use it straight.

Doing so is risky and foolish because by now we know that AI-generated text is full of "tells". Perhaps you've heard about em-dashes, for example?

It's not just em-dashes, though. Here's a site that provides [100 words and phrases](#) that are many times more common in AI text than human text.

And the site/tool Pangram (<https://www.pangram.com/>) can detect how much of a piece of text was AI-generated (here's more about their model: <https://www.pangram.com/research/how-it-works>).

Now, 5 tools to try

Here are the 5 tools I have actually used for writing and editing assistance: OpenAI's **ChatGPT**, Anthropic's **Claude**, Microsoft's **Co-Pilot**, DuckDuckGo's **DuckAI**, and Google's **Gemini**. They have some similarities and many differences, especially around privacy, costs, and environmental impacts.

Remember that Toothless the Dragon can't fly alone, because he is missing half his tail? He needs our hero Hiccup's custom-built mechanical rig—and constant adjustments—to get off the ground. Your prompts and feedback are that rig. Without your specific direction, input, and constraints, the AI will just crash (metaphorically, of course).

Similarities

All 5 tools have been trained on huge datasets to generate human-like text, supporting a variety of applications ranging from casual conversations and content creation to coding assistance. They all emphasize user privacy and data protection to varying degrees. As of this writing, all are available for free for at least a trial period.

Differences

- **ChatGPT:** OpenAI's viral smash hit. Known for its versatility, ChatGPT (<https://chatgpt.com/>) can do it all - general conversations and storytelling, drafting content, and yes - helping with homework.
 - **Pros:** Highly adaptable; strong community support; frequent updates.
 - **Cons:** Expensive monthly fee; retains user data
- **Claude:** Developed by Anthropic, Claude (<https://claude.ai/>) focuses on ethical AI use, promising nuanced understanding and safety features.
 - **Pros:** Ethical focus, minimal data retention, advanced machine-reasoning skills. Different versions have different environmental costs - the lighter-weight, cheaper models have lower costs.

- **Cons:** Can be slower than competitors.
- **Co-Pilot:** Most well known for its use in programming. In the latest open model [<https://copilot.microsoft.com/>], it can draft and edit emails, generate images, and -- supposedly -- predict the future. I couldn't get that to work.
 - **Pros:** Deep integration in coding workflows; good for developers.
 - **Cons:** Shares data with Microsoft.
- **DuckAI** [duck.ai]: Offers multi-functionality and user-friendly interactions, focusing on educational and casual uses.
 - **Pros:** User-friendly; good for educational contexts.
 - **Cons:** May lack depth in professional applications.
- **Gemini** [<https://gemini.google.com/app>]: Prized by business users; robust analytical capabilities and integration with Google services.
 - **Pros:** Strong analytics; beneficial for many uses including "vibe coding" and web development.
 - **Cons:** Concerns about data aggregation; privacy implications with integration.

Save the Planet

If you are concerned, as I am, with the environmental impact of these different tools, I have bad news. We don't really know. Full lifecycle (scope 3) disclosures are not available. What we do know is this:

- The median per-prompt energy usage for **Gemini** has been reported as ~0.24 Wh (watt hours). [<https://devera.ai/resources/environmental-impact-ai-energy-c...>]
- A typical short-text query to **ChatGPT** (model 4 family) used around ~0.3–0.45 Wh and results in ~0.1–0.2 g CO₂e (emissions). This varies by model variant, length, and datacenter grid, and larger "reasoning" variants can be many times higher.

Putting this into perspective, the median Gemini prompt costs the equivalent of running a standard household LED lightbulb for about **1.6 minutes** (or roughly 96 seconds).

However, when you multiply that 1.6 minutes by billions of queries globally every day, those fractions of a watt-hour rapidly add up to serious grid demand. I can only hope that the people and corporations behind these models and data centers will work on reducing their impacts on our shared planet. We should demand no less.

Next week, for the last installment of this series, I will be sharing what I've learned about using AI tools in job-hunting. Til then, happy flying!

Sincerely,

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